



International Student and Scholar Services

Immigration Policy Guide

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1 INTRODUCTION

PURPOSE OF THIS DOCUMENT

This document is to serve as a comprehensive guide specific to ISSS immigration practices.

2 F-1 STUDENT IMMIGRATION

MAINTAINING F-1 AND J-1 STATUS

F-1 and J-1 students have the responsibility to understand and comply with immigration regulations pertaining to their visa category. To maintain status, F-1 and J-1 students must fulfill minimum academic and immigration requirements described below.

FULL TIME ENROLLMENT

Students must enroll full-time each semester (Fall/Spring) to maintain immigration status. Enrollment during the summer is optional (except IAP/PSE/ACDC Extenders), unless summer is the first or last academic term, in which, enrollment is required.

Exceptions to full-time enrollment are described under the Reduced Course Load section.

Program	Full-Time Minimum Enrollment
Undergraduate/J.D.	12 credits
Graduate	9 credits
L.L.M/S.J.D.	8 credits
Abroad @ AU (ABAU)	12 Credits
Washington Semester Program (WSP) for credit	12 Credits
Washington Semester Program (WSP) noncredit	3 courses
IAP	12 Credits
ACDC	12 Credits
MAP	9 credits
PSE/ELTA	4 courses
WCL Human Rights Academy	6 credits per program
Panama Bilingual Program	27 hours or 1 class per each 8-week program.

Online Courses

Degree seeking F-1 students can take one online class (of a maximum of 3 credits) as part of their full-time enrollment requirement (or as part of their final semester RCL requirement). J-1 students cannot take online classes as part of their full-time or RCL requirement.

Enrollment in online courses of more than 3 credits are reviewed carefully by ISSS if they are to be part of the minimum enrollment requirement as they are treated as exceptions. ISSS contacts the student and academic advisors to understand academic needs. PDSO approval is required.

Degree seeking F-1 students can take additional online courses beyond their minimum full-time or RCL enrollment requirement.

J-1 students - In April 2017, the Department of State advised that one online class per year was permitted for J-1 students. Taking into consideration the nature of the Exchange Visitor Program and for the best interest of our students, ISSS practice is to not recommend online classes for J-1 students, even if students have fulfilled their minimum enrollment with in-person classes. Requests are reviewed case-by-case and permission may be granted by the RO in rare cases where there is an academic need.

Online Courses from Online Programs

Students cannot enroll in online courses from online programs, such as T1-4 courses. These courses do not align with the standard academic calendar approved by DHS on the I-17.

Requests to enroll in online courses from online programs are carefully reviewed and require PDSO approval. ISSS may grant authorization if there is documented academic need and no other options are available. For example, the online course is necessary for the student to graduate on-time and that is the only option available. Examples: 402707, 5395182, 5403897, 5386744.

Programs that Do Not Allow Online Classes

Online classes are not permitted as part of ELTA, Pre-Sessional English Language program (PSE), and Pathway programs (IAP and MAP).

Online classes are not recommended as part of the American Access (ACDC) program. One online class per semester may be authorized case by case as an exception, depending on academic need and availability.

Online classes are not permitted as part of the Panama Bilingual program.

Online classes are not recommended as part of any J-1 program.

Summer Enrollment

Summer enrollment is required for PSE, IAP, ACDC extenders, and degree seeking students starting or ending their academic program in the **summer**.

Degree seeking students who have their first semester in the summer must maintain full-time enrollment and are limited to one online class as part of this requirement (F-1 students). J-1 students no online classes.

Degree seeking students who decide to finish their program in the summer can enroll full-time or part-time. They must enroll in at least one in-person class to maintain immigration status.

ISSS practice is to not issue I-20's with a summer start date as most schools cannot offer a full course load in the summer. Additionally, there are increased chances of classes being cancelled due to low enrollment in the summer. Rare exceptions are reviewed and approved by the PDSO.

Degree-seeking change of level (COL) students who finish one academic level at the end of spring cannot take summer courses. Exceptions are reviewed if:

1. there is written confirmation from the academic advisor there are enough credits available for the student to maintain full-time enrollment over the summer and courses will be applied for the next academic level.
2. there is an admission record (PIIRF) for the summer.

Pre-sessional English (PSE), undergraduate (IAP), and graduate (MAP) students who progress at the end of spring may enroll in summer courses at AU if:

1. students receive permission from their academic advisor.
2. the courses will be applied for the next academic level.
3. the courses will be coded as non-degree for the summer by the academic advisor.
4. the non-degree code will be updated by the academic advisor at the beginning of fall.

American Access (ACDC) students who complete their academic program at the end of spring may enroll in summer courses at AU if:

3. students receive permission from their academic advisor.
4. the courses will be applied for the next academic level.
5. the courses will be coded as non-degree for the summer by the academic advisor.
6. the non-degree code will be updated by the academic advisor at the beginning of fall.
7. there is an admission record for the student in the system (PIIRF) as proof of intention to enroll at AU in the fall.

Study Abroad and Doctorate Field Research Abroad

F-1 students participating in an approved study abroad program or conducting doctorate field research abroad must maintain full-time enrollment to maintain status. Their SEVIS record are kept active.

J-1 students cannot participate in study abroad programs or conduct doctorate field research abroad. If J-1 students select to spend time abroad during their program at AU, their SEVIS record must be shortened.

Exception: doctorate J-1 students who are required as part of their academic program at AU to conduct field research abroad and are authorized by their financial sponsor to spend time abroad may have authorization granted by ISSS. In addition to the [Doctorate Field Research Abroad form](#), they must provide a letter from their financial sponsor acknowledging and authorizing travel.

O99 Maintaining Matriculation

Students enrolled in maintaining matriculation do not maintain immigration status. Students need enrollment in at least one (1) academic credit to maintain F-1 and J-1 status in the fall, spring, and summer (if final semester). Exceptions exist under the zero-credit medical RCL.

Switching Classes After Add and Drop

Students are advised to work with their academic advisor to add the new class first before dropping the current one, to avoid the risk of falling out of status.

Waitlisted students must maintain full-time enrollment until a final decision is made on which courses they can join.

SATISFACTORY ACADEMIC PROGRESS

To maintain immigration status, F-1 and J-1 students are required to make normal academic progress towards the completion of academic program. Students who finish their program by their I-20/DS-2019 end date are considered to have made normal academic progress.

It is ISSS practice to follow American University's academic rules and regulations regarding what is needed for students to maintain satisfactory academic progress. Maintaining the minimum GPA is one of the requirements for most programs:

Minimum GPA	
Undergraduate/JD/LLM	2.00
Graduate	3.00
SJD	no GPA requirement
WCL Human Rights Academy	2.00

The SJD program differs from the other law programs in that the students do not take traditional courses, nor do they receive letter grades. They do not have a GPA. The SJD Colloquium (Law-999) is pass/fail. First-year students must pass both semesters (fall and spring) to proceed to the upper level of the program. They are permitted to audit a few law courses in the first year and receive no academic credit for those. The remainder of the program is generally completed through research and writing supervised by the candidate's advisor. At the end of each semester, the program director, [Elizabeth Cavanagh](#), certifies that each student has made satisfactory progress in their research/writing and the Pass is recorded on the transcript.

English Language Training Academy (ELTA) and Pre-Sessional English Language Program (PSE)

Students in the ELTA or PSE program must maintain a minimum attendance rate of 90% in each class to be considered making satisfactory academic progress. Students who fail to maintain the minimum attendance rate receive FX or ZX grades for the class(es) not attended and are administratively separated (dismissed) from the program. ISSS terminates their record in SEVIS.

Students in the ELTA or PSE program who fail one or more classes must repeat the entire level. Levels can be repeated one time only in a consecutive term.

IAP and MAP

At the undergraduate level, the Extended Accelerator (EAP) has 4 terms; student can complete in 3 or 4 terms. The Academic Accelerator (AAP) and the Integrated Accelerator (IAP) have 3 terms; student can complete in 2 or 3 terms.

At the graduate level, the master's Accelerator (MAP) has 3 terms; student can complete in 2 or 3 terms. The Advanced master's Accelerator (AMAP) has 2 terms; students can complete in 1 or 2 terms.

Students in pathway programs must complete courses in consecutive terms and maintain regular class attendance as stated on course syllabi to be considered making satisfactory academic progress. Additionally, students must be enrolled in semester classes that enable them to meet required pre-requisites to enroll in subsequent semester classes.

Students who fail to maintain the minimum attendance rate receive FX or ZX grades for the class(es) not attended and are administratively separated (dismissed) from the program. ISSS terminates their records in SEVIS.

American Access Program (ACDC)

The American Access program has 3 terms; student can complete in 2 or 3 terms. The Extended American Access program has 4 terms; students can complete in 3 or 4 terms.

Students in the American Access program must maintain regular class attendance as stated on course syllabi to be considered making satisfactory academic progress. Additionally, students must be enrolled in semester classes that enable them to meet required pre-requisites to enroll in subsequent semester classes.

Students in the American Access program who fail to maintain regular attendance receive FX or ZX grades for the class(es) not attended. Students are administratively separated (dismissed) from the program if FX or ZX grades places them below full-time enrollment for the term. ISSS terminates their record in SEVIS.

Abroad at AU (ABAU), Washington Semester Program (WSP), Graduate Professional Studies (GPS), Panama Bilingual Program

J-1 students enrolled in these programs must maintain regular class attendance as stated on course syllabi and must complete all required coursework in a timely manner to be considered making satisfactory academic progress.

VALID IMMIGRATION DOCUMENTS

Passport

Students must hold a valid passport. ISSS practice is to recommend students to maintain a passport that is valid for at least 6 months in the future. Students planning to apply for post-completion OPT are recommended to have a passport that is valid for at least until the end of their OPT.

Students can renew their passport in the U.S or back home. Failure to hold a valid passport may result in the loss of immigration benefits.

Visa

Students from Canada and Bermuda are exempt from the visa requirement.

All other students are required an F-1 or J-1 visa to enter the U.S. and can stay in the country with an expired visa if they have a valid I-20/DS-2019 and are otherwise maintaining F-1/J-1 status. Visas must be renewed abroad before students apply for readmission into the U.S.

ISSS practice is to recommend students to renew their visas back in their home country and to alert them of the risks of renewing it in a third country.

Students with multiple visas in their passport must re-enter the U.S. using their unexpired F-1 or J-1 visa to continue their academic program or their post-completion OPT or post-completion AT.

Automatic Visa Revalidation

Automatic visa revalidation allows most F-1 and J-1 students to take a trip of less than 30 days to Canada, Mexico or the contiguous islands and reenter on an expired visa provided they have proper documentation and have not applied for a new visa during their visit. This process revalidates the visa (making it eligible for the single trip) but does not renew it.

Automatic visa revalidation is not recommended for students re-entering the United States with a new initial I-20. For example, students who are not eligible for program extension and receive a new initial I-20 and must travel abroad and re-enter the U.S. on the initial I-20.

I-20/DS-2019

Students must maintain an unexpired I-20 or DS-2019. Students who are unable to finish their program by the end date stated on their I-20 or DS-2019 must contact ISSS to discuss their immigration eligibility for program extension. Program extensions must be requested 2-3 months before the current document expires. PDSO approval is required for program extension.

I-94 Admission Record

ISSS recommends students to retrieve their most current I-94 each time they travel abroad and re-enter the United States. Students who, after multiple attempts, cannot retrieve their most current I-94, are recommended to go to Dulles or BWI deferred inspection's unit.

SEVIS REGISTRATION FOR ACTIVE F-1 STUDENTS

Students are expected to be in the U.S. by the first day of classes. Late arrivals must be discussed and approved by the academic department. Late arrivals are usually not allowed by academic departments beyond the second week of classes.

SEVIS Registration dates for WCL follows WCL's academic calendar. SEVIS Registration dates for the main campus follows the main campus's academic calendar.

Semester dates to be used for reduced course load (RCL), I-20 shortening (program completion), and Curricular Practical Training (CPT) follow the WCL or the main campus academic calendars and must be set within the SEVIS Registration dates for the semester:

RCL Dates		
Main Campus		
Term	Start Date	End Date
Fall	First day of classes	Commencement day
Spring	First day of classes	Commencement last day
Summer (IAP/PSE)	Day after Spring commencement	Day before Fall first day of classes
WCL		
Term	Start Date	End Date
Fall	First day of classes	WCL Final day of exams or main campus commencement day (whichever is later)
Spring	First day of classes	Commencement day

CPT Authorization Dates		
Main Campus		
Term	Start Date	End Date
Fall	First day of classes	Last day of classes
Spring	First day of classes	Last day of classes
Summer Break	Day after Spring commencement	Day before Fall first day of classes

WCL		
Term	Start Date	End Date
Fall	First day of classes	Last day of classes
Spring	First day of classes	Last day of classes
Summer Break	Day after Spring commencement	Day before Fall first day of classes

I-20s are shortened to commencement day in fall and spring. In the summer, I-20s are shortened to the official degree award date, unless students are applying for post-completion OPT, in which case, I-20s are shortened to the student's last day of classes or the defense date (PhDs).

Priority Groups for Fall and Spring SEVIS Registration

WCL students, students on approved study abroad, and students on approved doctorate field research abroad are registered as separate groups in SEVIS and as priority before a group batch is sent.

Summer SEVIS Registration

PSE and IAP students are required to enroll in the summer and must be registered in SEVIS. IAP summer extenders are eligible for reduced course load (RCL). RCL must be reported in SEVIS.

Currently, ACDC does not require summer enrollment, unless students are extenders in the summer. In this scenario, summer becomes a required term and summer SEVIS registration is needed. Summer extenders are also eligible for reduced course load (RCL).

Study Abroad and Doctorate Field Research Abroad

Students on approved study abroad programs or conducting field research abroad in fall or spring must change their current U.S. physical address to the ISSS office address *Butler Pavilion 410, 4400 Massachusetts Ave., NW 20016* for the duration of their time abroad.

Students on approved study abroad programs or conducting field research abroad in the summer are not required to change their U.S. physical address, since there is no summer SEVIS Registration for this group.

MAINTENANCE OF UPDATED CONTACT INFORMATION

F-1 and J-1 students must report any changes in address or contact information to ISSS within 10 days through iEagle.

Changes in name, date of birth, and gender are reported through the university's online Personal Data Change form. The online form is routed to ISSS (Yui) and then to AU Central. ISSS issues an updated I-20/DS-2019 after confirming the change in the passport.

Students are also recommended to update the university with any changes:

- a. Log in to the MyAU Portal
- b. Click on Academics tab.
- c. Click on Contact Information (current student)
- d. Select what would like to update: home country/permanent information, US current information, or emergency contact.

HEALTH INSURANCE

Students are automatically enrolled in American University's health insurance. Students can request to waive AU's health insurance by contacting AU Central. It's extremely difficult to have the waiver approved.

AU's health insurance meets all immigration requirements for the J-1 program. J-1 and J-2 dependents must maintain health insurance coverage for the entire period of their program at AU and are expected to be insured from day one as soon as they arrive in the U.S. J-1 students must notify ISSS of any changes on health insurance coverage within 10 days by submitting a new Insurance Verification e-form in iEagle.

Graduating F-1 students applying for Post Completion Optional Practical Training (OPT) and graduating J-1 students applying for Post Completion Academic Training (AT) can request to extend their AU health insurance beyond graduation. Requests must be submitted and received by AU Central before their current coverage expires.

TRAVEL AND RE-ENTRY

Traveling Within the United States

F-1 and J-1 students traveling inside the U.S. do not need their I-20/DS-2019 signed for travel.

ISSS practice is to recommend students to carry their passport, visa, I-20/DS-2019, and their most recent I-94 admission record. These documents can be used for identification and as a confirmation of their immigration status in the U.S.

It is also ISSS practice to recommend students to keep hard and/or electronic copies of these documents for their own records in case originals are lost or damaged.

Traveling Abroad

F-1 and J-1 students traveling abroad must carry their most recent I-20 or DS-2019 with an unexpired travel signature, together with their unexpired passport, and unexpired visa. Travel signatures are valid for one (1) year from the date signed; except for students on Post Completion Optional Practical Training (OPT) or STEM OPT, in which travel signatures are valid for six (6) months from the date signed.

F-1 students receive an electronic travel signature on their electronic I-20 and can request it using iEagle. J-1 students must bring their physical DS-2019 to ISSS to have it signed by hand. During the pandemic, J-1 students were required to schedule a “document pick up” appointment to bring their DS2019 to the ISSS. 

A list of what to carry for their re-entry into the U.S. is available in ISSS’s webpage:
<https://www.american.edu/ocl/iss/iss/travel-and-re-entry.cfm>

ISSS cannot advise on travel and entry requirements to other countries. ISSS recommends students to check with the country’s Embassy or Consulate that they wish to visit for more information on required documents.

Traveling Abroad in First Semester

Students who arrived in the U.S. using an initial I-20 or DS2019 must first submit their required immigration registration in iEagle, have their immigration record activated in SEVIS, and receive a travel signature before they can depart the U.S.

ISSS does not recommend departing the U.S. right after arrival unless there is an emergency.

Traveling Abroad in Final Semester

Students must return to the U.S. prior to their last day of classes to preserve immigration benefits associated with their F-1 or J-1 immigration status.

Students who travel abroad during their 60-day grace period (F-1 students) or 30-day grace period (J-1 students) after program completion, cannot return to the U.S. using their F-1 or J-1 status.

Students who have applied for Post-completion OPT (F-1 students) are not recommended to travel abroad until after their OPT has been approved and they have received their EAD card and secured employment. They can travel abroad and return to the U.S. before their last day of classes, while still taking courses. In this case, an EAD card is not needed.

For students who applied for Post-completion AT (J-1 students), they are not recommended to travel abroad until they receive their updated DS-2019 showing the AT employment authorization.

Travel Signature

Travel signatures are given to students who are maintaining good academic and immigration status. Requests for travel signature are reviewed by advisors on duty at the front desk.

ISSS practice is to check the following before signing for travel:

- a. student’s enrollment and GPA,
- b. I-20/DS-2019 end date,

- c. SEVIS registration
- d. passport and visa,
- e. contact information,
- f. Sunapsis notes and pending alerts, and
- g. EAD and employer reports (for students on post-completion OPT)

J-1 scholars need to submit the "out-of-country" form to ISSS for approval if they plan to stay abroad for more than two (2) weeks.

Travel Signature Issues – Follow Up Needed

Passport - travel signatures are not given to students with expiring passports until ISSS receives a copy of the renewed passport. Student must report their renewed passport in iEagle.

I-20/DS-2019 - travel signatures are not given to students with an expiring I-20 or DS-2019 until:

- a. an extended document is issued or
- b. there is confirmation from the student the re-entry will occur before their document end date and while school is still in session. ISSS will advise on the risks of traveling close to the I-20 or DS-2019 expiration date and alert that re-entry under the F-1 or J-1 visa is not possible during the grace period. Unless there is an emergency, ISSS will discourage students from traveling close to their I-20/DS-2019 end date.

Change of level (COL) students will be advised to re-enter using their new initial I-20.

Enrollment – travel signatures are not given to students under-enrolled without RCL. If the travel signature is requested after classes are over, students must have enrollment in at least one course for the next semester before ISSS can sign.

Low GPA, probation, potential dismissal, or administrative separation – travel signatures are not given to students at risk of termination until there is confirmation from the academic department they are allowed to continue in the program. ISSS advises students on the immigration implications of not maintaining good academic status, such as, termination of status or non-eligibility for program extension.

Visa – travel signatures are given to students with expiring visas. ISSS advises students they must renew it while abroad. ISSS also advises in cases of single-entry visas.

Contact information – travel signatures are given to students with missing personal email or U.S. phone number. ISSS reminds them to report to ISSS if they have one.

Re-entry after Absence of 5 months or more

Current Department of State and Homeland Security guidance indicates that if a student visa has not been canceled or has not expired, it may be used to re-enter the U.S. using a new initial attendance I-20.

Due to conflicting information regarding the 5-month rule and the need for a new visa in cases where the I-20 was terminated, ISSS practice is to recommend students to contact their local U.S. Consulate abroad to further discuss their visa validity.

REDUCED COURSE LOAD (RCL)

ELIGIBILITY

With provided documentation, exceptions to full course of study can be authorized for the following reasons:

- a) initial academic difficulties.
- b) illness or medical conditions.
- c) completion of course of study.

Students are considered maintaining immigration status while on approved RCL and can apply for immigration benefits, such as on-campus employment, CPT, etc. For students experiencing severe medical problems, ISSS practice is to evaluate if employment is appropriate or advisable.

The minimum enrollment requirement under RCL is decided in consultation with the academic department and/or medical provider and is reviewed individually. Zero credit RCL is possible in rare medical circumstances with PDSO approval.

RCL is authorized and processed in SEVIS in fall and spring for degree seeking students. During summer, RCL is authorized and processed for programs that require summer enrollment/SEVIS Registration such as, PSE, IAP, and ACDC extenders.

The maximum number of authorizations and the maximum length students can be authorized for RCL are as follows:

RCL Reason	Number of Authorizations Allowed	Maximum Length
Initial Academic Difficulties	One time per academic level	First semester only
Illness or Medical Conditions	Up to three times per academic program/course of study	Up to three semesters (not passing 12 months per academic program/course of study)

Completion of Course of Study	Up to two times per academic program/course of study (second time if student fails to graduate only)	Final two semesters
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Students not Eligible for RCL

1. Students on approved study abroad and PhD's on approved field research abroad.
2. Students enrolled in short-term (one semester) non-degree and exchange programs.
3. Students who have taken all necessary credits for program completion, but graduation is postponed for other reasons, such as "specialization title" pending final approval. These students are not eligible for further enrollment and are considered done for immigration purposes.

Students enrolled in short-term non-degree and exchange programs that are at least two semesters long are eligible for medical RCL only. Cases are reviewed as exceptions. Prior PDSO/RO approval required.

O99 Maintaining Matriculation and RCL

Students enrolled in maintaining matriculation do not maintain immigration status. Students need enrollment in at least one (1) academic credit to maintain F-1 and J-1 status in fall, spring, and summer (if final semester). Exceptions exist under the zero-credit medical RCL with prior PDSO approval.

INITIAL ACADEMIC DIFFICULTIES

Degree seeking students (undergraduate and graduate) who experience initial difficulty with the English language or reading requirements, or unfamiliarity with U.S. teaching methods, or improper course level placement are eligible for initial academic difficulties RCL. PDSO approval required.

This RCL is available in the first semester only (and one time only per academic level) and students are expected to resume to full course of study at the next available term to maintain immigration status.

Use of an academic difficulty RCL does not affect eligibility for other RCLs.

Initial academic difficulties RCL is not available to the following programs:

- ELTA and PSE
- IAP/MAP
- American Access ACDC
- Abroad at AU
- Washington Semester Program

- Graduate Professional Studies
- WCL Human Rights Academy
- Panama Bilingual

ILLNESS OR MEDICAL CONDITIONS

Medical RCL can be authorized for degree seeking students and students in non-degree or exchange programs that are two semesters or more in length. PDSO approval is required.

Students experiencing a temporary illness or a medical condition that is preventing them to continue attending classes full-time are eligible for medical RCL providing that documentation from a licensed medical doctor, a licensed psychiatrist, a licensed psychologist or clinical psychologist, or a doctor of osteopathy in the U.S. is presented.

Medical RCL can be authorized multiple times, for up to three (3) semesters not to exceed 12 months per academic program (course of study).

Zero credit medical RCL student case: 5392564. RCL was authorized for the entire semester as the student was hospitalized for treatment by the time RCL was received by ISSS. In this case, ISSS did not ask for additional documentation explaining why treatment needed to be done in the U.S.

To compare, a previous zero credit medical RCL was approved for a student who was going to initiate treatment in the U.S. but was not hospitalized or had the treatment initiated by the time ISSS received the RCL request. In this case, ISSS asked for additional documentation showing why the treatment needed to be done in the US and not abroad.

COMPLETION OF COURSE OF STUDY

Final semester RCL is available to students who have fewer courses left in their last semester to complete their academic program. Final semester RCL can be authorized for degree seeking students and students in the PSE, IAP, and ACDC extenders.

Final semester RCL is not processed in SEVIS in the summer, except for PSE, IAP, and ACDC extenders.

Final semester RCL is approved once per academic program (course of study). In exceptional cases where a student fails a course and cannot graduate, a second consecutive final semester RCL can be approved. In this scenario, the student is required to enroll in at least one (1) credit in the next consecutive term to retake the failed course.

Scenarios:

- a. A student is approved for final semester RCL in the fall and fails a course. The student must enroll in at least one (1) credit in the spring and be authorized for a second final semester RCL to graduate. Example: 5034243

- b. A student is approved for final semester RCL in the spring and fails a course. The student must enroll in at least one (1) credit in the summer to graduate. Summer RCL is not processed in SEVIS.

Final Semester RCL and Online Classes

Students can take one online class (of a maximum of 3 credits) as part of their RCL requirement in the fall and spring. In the summer, if the final semester, students must enroll in at least one in-person course to maintain status.

Students with only one (1) class left to graduate must enroll in an in-person class (as determined by the university's catalog). If the required final course is only offered online, students have the option to add an additional in-person course to their schedule to stay in compliance.

The following courses are described as online, and students cannot take them as the only course left in their final semester:

- a. SIS internship classes (391, 491, or 691)
- b. CAS Spring capstone (ECON 680)

KSB 621

KSB 620 and KSB 621 must be done in consecutive semesters. KSB 621 is shown as 'lecture' in the university's catalog, but it is delivered online. Per KSB, students do not meet on-campus. Students cannot take KSB 621 as the only class left in their final semester.

RCL PROCESS

Eligible F-1 students are advised to submit the RCL request e-form in iEagle along with supporting documentation. The e-form is first routed to academic advisors for initial review and routed back to ISSS for final review and approval. Medical documentation attached to the e-form is only accessible to selected ISSS advisors. Academic advisors do not have access to it.

Initial Academic Difficulties Steps:

- a. students must meet with their academic advisor to discuss their academic challenges and academic options
- b. if no academic options are available and the RCL request can be supported academically, students must receive a supporting letter from their academic advisor
- c. students submit the RCL e-form (with the supporting letter attached)
- d. ISSS reviews the request within 3-5 business days and notify students

Medical RCL Steps:

- a. Students must meet with their medical provider to discuss their diagnosis and treatment options

- b. if RCL is recommended by the medical provider, students must receive a medical letter* from the provider
- c. students submit the RCL e-form (with the medical letter attached)
- d. ISSS reviews the request within 3-5 business days and notify students

*The medical letter must be in official letterhead, be signed, and should include: (a) description of the medical condition, including how it affects the student's ability to study full time; (b) details of current treatment; (c) recommendation of number of credits to enroll under Reduced Course Load; (d) recommendation of when the student may resume taking full-time course work.

Medical documentation provided by ASAC, and the Student Health Center may be accepted in certain cases. Documents from abroad must be officially translated into English and can be presented as supporting documentation only.

Final Semester RCL Steps:

- a. students must meet with their academic advisor to confirm their expected program completion date and to discuss what courses to enroll to ensure they can graduate on time.
- b. If fewer credits are needed, students must the RCL e-form
- e. For current term requests, ISSS reviews it within 3-5 business days and notify students
- c. For future term requests, ISSS reviews it closer to the next term start date and notify students

RCL Dates in SEVIS

RCL Dates		
Main Campus		
Term	Start Date	End Date
Fall	First day of classes	Commencement day
Spring	First day of classes	Commencement last day
Summer (IAP/PSE/ACDC Extenders)	Day after Spring commencement	End of summer session
WCL		
Term	Start Date	End Date
Fall	First day of classes	WCL final day of exams or main campus commencement day (whichever is later)
Spring	First day of classes	Commencement day

PROGRAM EXTENSION

ELIGIBILITY

Students who have continually maintained good academic and immigration status and are faced with delays in program completion due to compelling academic or medical reasons may be eligible for program extension. Extensions are not guaranteed and must be approved by the PDSO.

Students not eligible for program extension have the option to either finish their program from abroad (with departmental approval) or reapply to a new initial I-20, travel abroad, and re-enter the U.S to resume classes. In this scenario, eligibility for post-completion OPT is lost if students have only one semester left to graduate.

I-20's can be extended for up to one (1) year at a time. The maximum number of extensions allowed depends on each individual case.

Students may select to extend for one semester only based on individual academic and financial circumstances. However, ISSS practice is to recommend extensions for two semesters, whenever possible and appropriate, to avoid the need for a second extension in the future.

ISSS practice is to alert students that once an extension is granted, they are expected to finish their program by their new I-20 end date, as planned.

ISSS practice is to meet with students to discuss their case and assess their immigration eligibility before further advising on the process. Topics to be covered in the initial assessment meeting are as follows:

- a. reasons for the delay in program completion
- b. what is left to be done and the new expected program completion date
- c. enrollment and financial responsibilities for the extended period
- d. explore alternative options (for example, finish program by the current I-20 end date, finish program from abroad, etc.)

Acceptable Program Extension Reasons

- a. Delay due to initial academic difficulties
- b. Change in major
- c. Change in thesis or dissertation
- d. Unexpected research problems
- e. Illness or medical conditions
- f. Other academic reasons

Students not Eligible for Program Extension

Students who failed to maintain good academic and immigration status or have personal reasons for delay in program completion are not eligible for program extension.

Examples of failure to maintain good academic status:

1. taking random classes not related to major without prior consultation and adequate planning with the academic advisor
2. academic probation or suspension
3. failing/repeating classes
4. not progressing with dissertation in a timely manner as expected by the academic department

Examples of delays for personal reasons:

1. financial issues
2. family issues
3. healthy pregnancy

Examples of other non-acceptable reasons:

1. stress or one-time medical situation that does not require ongoing treatment
2. past illnesses or medical conditions that the student did not reach out for support (no previous medical RCL approved)
3. past initial academic difficulties that the student did not reach out for support (no previous initial difficulties RCL approved)

DELAY DUE TO INITIAL ACADEMIC DIFFICULTIES

Extensions based on initial academic difficulties are available for degree seeking students only (undergraduate and graduate).

Students who were previously approved for reduced course load (RCL) based on initial difficulty with the English language or reading requirements, or unfamiliarity with U.S. teaching methods, or improper course level placement are eligible for program extension if the need for the extension is a result of the reduced course load term.

CHANGE IN MAJOR

Undergraduate students who changed major are eligible for program extension if the changes were discussed, planned, and approved by the academic unit in advance.

Graduate students are admitted into specific programs and are not allowed to change majors. Graduate students who wish to pursue another academic program must apply and be admitted into the new program and are issued a new initial I-20. For this reason, they are not eligible for program extension based on change in major.

Students must plan to finish any minor or specialization within the timeframe allowed for their major.

CHANGE IN THESIS OR DISSERTATION

Doctoral students who change thesis or dissertation topics are eligible for program extension if the changes were discussed, planned, and approved by the academic department.

UNEXPECTED RESEARCH PROBLEMS

Doctoral students who encountered unexpected research problems are eligible for program extension if the problems were unforeseen and a new research plan was discussed, planned, and approved by the academic unit.

Examples of Unexpected Research Problems

Changes in access to data, data analysis or interviews impacted by external non-predictable events, unexpected changes in financial sponsorship, etc.

ILLNESS OR MEDICAL CONDITIONS

Students who are experiencing unexpected illness or a medical condition are eligible for program extension if medical documentation from a licensed medical doctor, licensed clinical psychologist, or doctor of osteopathy in the U.S. is provided.

Students who were previously approved for medical reduced course load (RCL) are eligible for program extension if the need for the extension is a result of the reduced course load term.

PROGRAM EXTENSION PROCESS

After initial assessment and confirmation of student's immigration eligibility, students are advised to submit the program extension request e-form in iEagle along with financial documents and any supporting documentation (when applicable).

Delay due to Initial Academic Difficulties Steps:

- a. student submits the e-form in iEagle
- b. the e-form is routed to the academic advisor to confirm the number of credits left to complete the academic program and the new program completion date
- c. the e-form is routed back to ISSS and is reviewed within 3-5 business days
- d. ISSS reconfirms there has been a previous initial academic difficulties RCL processed in SEVIS for the student before extending the I-20
- e. ISSS updates the financial information in SEVIS before extending the I-20

Delay due to Change in Major:

- a. student submits the e-form in iEagle
- b. the e-form is routed to the academic advisor to confirm the number of credits left to complete the academic program and the new program completion date
- c. the e-form is routed back to ISSS and is reviewed within 3-5 business days
- d. ISSS reconfirms immigration eligibility before extending the I-20
- e. ISSS updates the financial information in SEVIS before extending the I-20

Delay due to Change in Thesis or Dissertation:

- a. student works with the academic advisor/program director/dissertation chair/ to prepare a supporting letter. The letter must be approved and signed by the academic department and must include:
 - 1) what has changed, the reason for the change, and when it occurred
 - 2) what has been completed so far in the thesis or dissertation
 - 3) a timeline showing what is left to be done over the extended period with the expected completion date for each item
 - 4) the new expected program completion date for the student
- b. student submits the e-form in iEagle
- c. the e-form is routed to the academic advisor/program director/dissertation chair to confirm the new program completion date and attach the supporting letter
- d. the e-form is routed back to ISSS and is reviewed within 3-5 business days
- e. ISSS reviews the supporting letter for completeness and accuracy and reconfirms immigration eligibility before extending the I-20
- f. ISSS updates the financial information in SEVIS before extending the I-20

Delay due to Unexpected Research Problems:

- a. student works with the academic advisor/program director/dissertation chair/ to prepare a supporting letter. The letter must be approved and signed by the academic department and must include:
 - 1) description of unexpected problem and when it occurred
 - 2) what has been completed so far in the thesis or dissertation
 - 3) a timeline showing what is left to be done over the extended period with the expected completion date for each item
 - 4) the new expected program completion date for the student
- b. student submits the e-form in iEagle
- c. the e-form is routed to the academic advisor/program director/dissertation chair to confirm the new program completion date and attach the supporting letter
- d. the e-form is routed back to ISSS and is reviewed within 3-5 business days

- e. ISSS reviews the supporting letter for completeness and accuracy and reconfirms immigration eligibility before extending the I-20
- f. ISSS updates the financial information in SEVIS before extending the I-20

Delay due to Illness or Medical Condition (bachelor and master level students):

- a. student works with their medical provider for medical documentation *
- b. student submits the e-form in iEagle (with attached medical documentation)
- f. the e-form is routed to the academic advisor to confirm the number of credits left to complete the academic program and the new program completion date
- c. the e-form is routed back to ISSS and is reviewed within 3-5 business days
- d. ISSS reviews the medical documentation and reconfirms immigration eligibility before extending the I-20
- e. ISSS updates the financial information in SEVIS before extending the I-20

Delay due to Illness or Medical Condition (PhD students):

- a. student works with their medical provider for medical documentation *
- b. student works with the academic advisor/program director/dissertation chair/ to prepare a supporting letter. The letter must be approved and signed by the academic department and must include:
 - 1) what has been completed so far in the thesis or dissertation
 - 2) a timeline showing what is left to be done over the extended period and the expected completion date for each item
 - 3) the new expected program completion date for the student
- c. student submits the e-form in iEagle (with attached medical documentation)
- d. the e-form is routed to the academic advisor/program director/dissertation chair to confirm the new program completion date and attach the supporting letter
- e. the e-form is routed back to ISSS and is reviewed within 3-5 business days
- f. ISSS reviews the medical documentation and supporting letter for completeness and accuracy and reconfirms immigration eligibility before extending the I-20
- g. ISSS updates the financial information in SEVIS before extending the I-20

*Medical Documentation

For current illnesses or medical conditions:

The medical letter must be in official letterhead, be signed, and should include: (a) description of the medical condition, including how it affects the student's ability to continue making normal academic progress and graduate on time; (b) details of current treatment.

Medical documentation provided by ASAC, and the Student Health Center may be accepted in certain cases. Documents from abroad must be officially translated into English and can be presented as supporting documentation only.

For past illnesses or medical conditions (with medical RCL previously issued):

Medical documentation is a required field as part of the program extension e-form for medical reasons. For this reason, students can attach a copy of the previous medical letter submitted to ISSS for the medical RCL and/or any most recent documentation.

Failure to Request Program Extension Before I-20 End Date

Per the regulations, to be eligible for program extension, students must submit their request and have their I-20 extended before the expiration date. “A DSO may not grant an extension if the student did not apply for an extension until after the program end date noted on the Form I-20.” 8 CFR 214.2(f)(7)(iii).

If the student timely applied for extension but the DSO fails to extend before the I-20 end date, the PDSO has 15 days after the I-20 end date to correct and extend the I-20 in SEVIS. Requests for program extension after the I-20 end date are carefully reviewed and approved by the PDSO.

New Initial I-20 for Student Not Eligible for Program Extension

Students not eligible for program extension have the option to either finish their academic program from abroad (with departmental approval) or to request a new initial I-20.

New Initial I-20 Process for Students Not Eligible for Program Extension:

1. Students work with the active student team for initial advice on the process and travel timelines.
2. Students request a new I-20 using the “Request I-20” e-form in iEagle. They select the option “not eligible for program extension.”
3. The admissions team processes the new I-20 with remarks “student is returning to complete academic program.”
4. The active student team is notified by email at issimmigration that the new I-20 was issued and made available to the student.
5. The active student team reaches out to the student for further advice.
6. The student submits a new immigration registration upon arrival and is activated in SEVIS by the admissions team

ISSS practice is to let the previous SEVIS record auto complete by SEVIS at the end of the grace period. Students are advised they may have two active SEVIS records by the time they re-enter the U.S.

CLOSING F-1 AND J-1 IMMIGRATION RECORDS: SHORTENING, SEVIS COMPLETION, AND TERMINATION

Shortening (Graduation, Program completion, Change of level)

F-1 and J-1 students who graduate, complete their academic program, or change level have their I-20/DS-2019 shortened by ISSS. Their SEVIS record will auto complete by SEVIS at the end of their grace period.

I-20 Shortening Dates	
Main Campus	
Term	I-20 Shortening Date
Fall	Commencement day
Spring	Commencement day
Summer	End of summer session or last day of classes (if applying for OPT)
WCL	
Term	I-20 Shortening Date
Fall	WCL final day of exams or main campus commencement day (whichever is later)
Spring	Commencement day
Summer	Official degree award date

ISSS reaches out to the Registrar's office each semester to remind them that graduation clearance needs to be prioritized/expedited for international students to meet DHS reporting deadlines.

ISSS also reaches out to other programs in which there is no graduation, for example, ELTA, IAP, ABAU, change of level students, to remind them of the deadline for final confirmation of program completion.

For graduating students, ISSS will shorten the I-20/DS-2019 after the degree has been posted in the transcript. For students completing their program or changing level, ISSS will shorten the I-20/DS-2019 after final confirmation of program completion.

ISSS practice is to notify students by email of their new I-20 end date and their grace period after shortening the I-20.

Once students take all required credits for their major they must graduate and are no longer eligible for continuous enrollment. Students planning to add minors or specializations must plan to finish them at the same time they complete their major.

Non-graduating Students in the Sunapsis Program Completion Alert

Students who finish a specialization or certificate, or PhD students who finish their master's portion appear on the program completion alert in Sunapsis. These students have not graduated, and the alert must be overridden. No action is taken on their I-20/DS-2019.

ISSS practice is to always check if the degree posted in the transcript matches the academic level appearing on the I-20/DS-2019 and the academic level information displayed in Sunapsis before shortening the record.

Failure to Graduate (I-20 Not Expiring)

Retaking Courses or Incomplete Grades

With RCL - Students in their final semester, who had an RCL approved, and who fail a course or receive an incomplete, must enroll in at least 1 credit to retake the failed course or to finish the incomplete course in the next consecutive term (fall/spring/summer) if they wish to maintain an active immigration status.

Without RCL – Students in their final semester, who were enrolled full-time, and who fail a course or receive an incomplete, must enroll in at least 1 credit to retake the failed course in the next semester if they wish to maintain an active immigration status. Summer enrollment is optional in this case.

Applied for Post-completion OPT – Students with a pending OPT application with USCIS by the time the final grade was posted, are advised to finish all academic requirements for degree completion as soon as possible and before the OPT start date.

Comprehensive Exam

With RCL - Students in their final semester, who had an RCL approved, and fail their comprehensive exam, must retake the exam as soon as possible and no later than next consecutive term. (fall/spring/summer) if they wish to maintain an active immigration status. If the exam will be retaken in the next consecutive term, it must be accompanied by at least 1 credit enrollment.

Without RCL - Students in their final semester, who were enrolled full-time, and fail their comprehensive exam, and have the academic option to retake it in the next semester, must enroll in at least 1 credit in the next semester to maintain an active immigration status.

Applied for Post-completion OPT – Students with a pending OPT application with USCIS by the time the exam result was posted, are advised to finish all academic requirements for degree completion as soon as possible and before the OPT start date.

Failure to Graduate (I-20 Expiring)

Students who fail to complete all academic requirements for degree completion by their I-20 end date have the option to finish their program from abroad (with departmental approval) or to apply for a new initial I-20 and enroll in credits to maintain an active immigration status. In this scenario, they will lose their eligibility to apply for OPT.

Applied for Post-completion OPT – Students with a pending OPT application with USCIS by the time they learn they cannot graduate are advised to finish all academic requirements for degree completion as soon as possible and before the OPT start date.

Graduation Postponed for Other Reasons

Students who have taken all necessary credits for program completion, but graduation is postponed for other reasons, such as “specialization title” pending final approval. These students are not eligible for further enrollment and are considered done for immigration purposes.

Program Completion in the Summer

Students finishing their academic program in the summer must have summer enrollment to maintain an active immigration status. Students must enroll in at least one in-person class.

Program Completion in the Winter Break

International students cannot enroll in winter session courses. Rare exceptions are reviewed with the PDSO for approval.

According to the Registrar’s office, students who take their final courses over the winter break will be considered as spring graduates. For immigration purposes, these students are considered December graduates, and have the I-20 shortened to the last day of winter classes.

Program Completion for PhD Students

Students who defend their dissertation after the spring semester end date and do not enroll in 899 during the summer will have their I-20 shortened to the spring commencement date. They may be eligible for OPT if their dissertation defense date is within their 60-day grace period.

Students who defend their dissertation after the fall semester end date and before the last day to add and drop in the spring do not need to enroll in spring classes. They have their I-20 shortened to their defense date and may apply for OPT based on that.

Students who defend their dissertation in the summer and are enrolled in 899 over the summer may select a program completion date as their defense date or the summer’s session last day of finals.

SEVIS Completion

Completion of SEVIS record applies to F-1 students only. J-1 students have their record shortened only.

F-1 students have their SEVIS record manually completed under the following circumstances:

- a) Final semester students who decide (with departmental approval) to finish their program from abroad. ISSS advises on their non eligibility to return to apply for post-completion OPT.
- b) OPT students who decide to end OPT early and depart the U.S.
- c) Ritsumeikan students who have completed their AU portion of the program. Their enrollment at RU shows on the AU transcript and Sunapsis shows them as full-time enrolled when they are no longer in the United States. Their immigration record must be completed in SEVIS. [Christine Gettings](#), Director of International Programs and Partnerships, School of International Service is the point of contact. She must send ISSS a list of students to be completed. Sample student case: Doke, Aoi 4940334
- d) Exceptional cases in which shortening, or termination are not an option. PDSO approval required. Examples:
 - 1. ISSS is notified very late of a program completion beyond the student's grace period. In this case, ISSS needs to shorten and complete the record as SEVIS will not auto complete.
 - 2. PhD students who are not eligible for field research abroad. They have not completed their program, so shortening is not an option. Their record needs to be completed.

SEVIS records are not completed in SEVIS until confirmation the student has departed the U.S.

TERMINATION

Below is a chart with the most used termination reasons for active F-1 students in ISSS. J-1 students should not be terminated, unless under exceptional circumstances only. Terminations must not be processed without prior PDSO approval.

Termination Reason	SEVIS Termination Reason
temporary leave (TLA)	authorized early withdrawal (AEW)
semester withdrawal	authorized early withdrawal (AEW)
voluntary separation (VS)	authorized early withdrawal (AEW)
academic or disciplinary dismissal	expulsion
administrative separation	expulsion
suspension	suspension
change of status (COS)	change of status approved
unauthorized part time	unauthorized drop below full course
failure to enroll	failure to enroll
failure to maintain status otherwise	otherwise failing to maintain status (with explanatory remarks)
F-2 dependent termination	Child over 21, death, divorce, other

Initial F-1 students with records indicating they entered the U.S. using AU's initial I-20 but never reported to ISSS have their record terminated in SEVIS based on "no show manual termination."

Initial F-1 students with records indicating they have not entered the U.S. using AU's initial I-20 or they have entered using a different immigration status and do not plan to be on F-1 status have their record cancelled in SEVIS. The cancellation reason is "not attending" with remarks.

Temporary Leave (TLA)

Temporary leave can be processed for current or future semesters only; retroactive temporary leave for students who were maintaining immigration status is not possible.

F-1 students on approved temporary leave have their immigration record terminated in SEVIS based on authorized early withdrawal (AEW).

Per the academic regulations, degree seeking students may have up to two (2) semesters of general or medical temporary leave. For military leave, students may have up to four (4) semesters. A petition for additional semesters of temporary leave is possible. Students must be advised by their academic advisor on the allowed number of temporary leaves they can apply.

ISSS practice is to check if the student has been on temporary leave previously before signing the temporary leave form. If the student has reached the initial allowed number of temporary leaves, ISSS advises the student to discuss with their academic advisor first if they can apply for additional time and to be advised on the petition process.

ISSS practice is to sign TLA forms and schedule the termination right after. Students who change mind or are petitioning for additional temporary leave time must notify ISSS immediately if the petition is not approved or they no longer plan to be on temporary leave (before the record is terminated).

ISSS practice is to advise students to submit a TLA request only after they are certain of their decision and have a departure plan in place.

IAP and MAP students are eligible for up to two (2) semesters of medical temporary leave only.

The following students are not eligible for temporary leave:

- English Language Training Academy (ELTA)
- Pre-Sessional English Language Program (PSE)
- American Access Program (ACDC)
- WCL Human Rights Academy
- Certificate Programs (Undergraduate/Graduate)
- Abroad at AU (ABAU)
- Washington Semester Program (WSP)

- Graduate Professional Studies (GPS)
- Panama Bilingual Program

Temporary leave can be approved for one (1) or two (2) semesters (Fall/Spring) at a time, depending on each school's policy. For programs in which summer is a required term for SEVIS registration, temporary leave may be processed in the summer. For example, a summer medical temporary leave for an IAP student.

By the academic regulations, students have until the last day to add and drop to apply for temporary leave. Students who wish to withdraw after the add and drop receive Ws in their transcript. For immigration purposes, they are considered as semester withdrawals.

By DHS guidance, students must be either enrolled or on temporary leave by the first day of classes.

ISSS timeline for applying for temporary leave is as follows:

- 1) Students not enrolled with no intention to enroll: by no later than the first day of classes
- 2) Students enrolled who change mind last minute: by the last day to add and drop

ISSS practice is to advise all students to submit and have their temporary leave request processed by the first day of classes. Enrolled students who change mind last minute are treated as exceptions.

Military Temporary Leave

Students on approved military leave must provide official proof of military service to ISSS.

Medical Temporary Leave

Medical temporary leaves are reviewed by Dean of Students (DOS), and medical documentation does not come to ISSS. Students returning from medical leave must submit the "Readiness to Return" form to DOS to be cleared before they can enroll in classes.

All temporary leaves are treated the same in terms of SEVIS termination. International students who apply for "medical leave" cannot stay in the U.S and must have their records terminated.

Temporary Leave Timelines and Process

Students must enter in the TLA form which semester(s) they wish to be on leave and when they expect to return.

Temporary Leave Requests for the CURRENT SEMESTER

Students are expected to depart the United States as soon as possible and before their SEVIS record is terminated. Generally, records are terminated within two (2) weeks after they initiated the process/signed the temporary leave form. However, many times, ISSS is required to terminate records sooner.

A “termination warning” email with the exact date the record will be terminated is sent to students right after ISSS signs the TLA form.

The complete steps on how to process a TLA request is saved here: K:\ISSS\Manuals\Front Desk Guide

Temporary Leave Requests for a FUTURE SEMESTER

Students who are enrolled and maintaining good academic and immigration status in the current semester and plan to be on temporary leave starting next semester, are expected to depart the United States as soon as they finish their courses for the current semester.

Their SEVIS record will be terminated a few weeks prior to the start of the new semester. A “termination warning” email with the exact date the record will be terminated is sent to students few weeks prior to the start of the new semester.

The complete steps on how to process a TLA request is saved here: K:\ISSS\Manuals\Front Desk Guide

Temporary Leave Requests Received in the SUMMER

During summer, students who are not enrolled in summer courses and initiate the process for temporary leave for the fall, are expected to depart the United States as soon as possible and before their SEVIS record is terminated (usually within two (2) weeks). They are no longer entitled to summer vacation in the U.S.

Semester Withdrawal – Between a Day After the Last Day to Add and Drop Until the Last Day of Classes

Withdrawals can be processed for current or future semesters only; retroactive withdrawals for students who were maintaining immigration status is not possible.

F-1 students who withdraw from all classes (and notify ISSS) have their immigration record terminated in SEVIS based on authorized early withdrawal (AEW).

Per the academic regulations, students who withdraw from all classes for current or future semesters before the last day to add and drop and indicate an intention to return to AU in the future are placed on temporary leave. If there is no intention to return to AU, students are processed for voluntary separation by the Registrar’s office.

Semester withdrawals occur between a day after the last day to add and drop until the last day of classes. Students receive Ws in the transcript if the request is received before the 10th week. After the 10th week, students have their final grade posted.

Students must work with their academic advisor to submit the correct form. ISSS practice is to clarify with students if they have the intention to return to AU upon receiving a request to withdraw from all classes.

It is also ISSS practice to advise students to submit a semester withdrawal only after they are certain of their decision and have a departure plan in place.

For immigration purposes, withdrawal requests can be submitted and processed by no later than the last day of classes. For late semester withdrawals, students may have only a few days left to depart the U.S. before ISSS terminates the record before the last day of classes.

For semester withdrawals, students submit the “Request for Registration Action” form indicating the term they wish to withdraw from all classes.

Students are expected to depart the United States as soon as possible and before their SEVIS record is terminated. Generally, records are terminated within two (2) weeks after they initiated the process/signed the Request for Registration Action form. However, many times, ISSS is required to terminate records sooner.

A “termination warning” email with the exact date the record will be terminated is sent to students right after ISSS confirms with students of their intention to withdraw for the semester and signs the form.

The complete steps on how to process a Request for Registration Action form and a Semester Withdrawal (WD) request is saved here: K:\ISSS\Manuals\Front Desk Guide

Students returning from a semester withdrawal follow the same steps for students returning from temporary leave.

Voluntary Separation (VS)

Students who decide to voluntarily separate from AU have their immigration record terminated in SEVIS based on authorized early withdrawal (AEW) or have their SEVIS record transferred out to another school in the U.S.

ISSS practice is to advise students to submit a VS request only after they are certain of their decision and either have a departure plan in place or have received admissions from another school and have submitted their transfer out request.

Voluntary separation can be requested at any time. However, students who wish to transfer out must coordinate to have their SEVIS record released first before the voluntary separation is processed by the university.

ISSS does not process mid semester transfers (with rare exceptions approved by the PDSO). For this reason, voluntary separations based on transfers are mostly processed before the first day of classes or after the semester is over after the SEVIS record has been scheduled for transfer.

For voluntary separation, students submit the “Request for Separation from the University” form. Students have the option to select the reason why they are leaving AU. ISSS practice is to follow up with students to understand if they have plans to transfer out and advise accordingly.

Voluntary Separation for Students Not Transferring Out

CURRENT SEMESTER - students are expected to depart the United States as soon as possible and before their SEVIS record is terminated. Generally, records are terminated within two (2) weeks after they initiated the process/signed the VS form. However, many times, ISSS is required to terminate records sooner.

A “termination warning” email with the exact date the record will be terminated is sent to students right after ISSS confirm the student intention of not transferring the SEVIS record and signs the form.

FUTURE SEMESTER - students who are enrolled and maintaining good academic and immigration status in the current semester and plan to separate from AU next semester, are expected to depart the United States as soon as they finish their courses for the current semester.

Their SEVIS record will be terminated a few weeks prior to the start of the new semester. A “termination warning” email with the exact date the record will be terminated is sent to students few weeks prior to the start of the new semester.

The complete steps on how to process a VS form is saved here: K:\ISSS\Manuals\Front Desk Guide

Academic or Disciplinary Dismissals

Dismissed F-1 students have their SEVIS record terminated based on expulsion with remarks “academic/disciplinary dismissal.”

ISSS must be copied on dismissal notifications from the academic department to the Registrar’s office. Many times, this process is not followed and ISSS is notified of academic dismissals either from the Registrar’s office directly or from academic advisors, or from students.

The point person for academic dismissals at the Registrar’s office is David Baratta.

Based on that, the process for academic dismissals is as follows:

- 1- Academic departments notify the Registrar's office of dismissal decisions and copy ISSS (or ISSS is notified of dismissals from the Registrar's directly, or from academic advisors, or from students).
- 2- ISSS confirms with the Registrar's they were notified of the dismissal and placed the student on the two (2) week hold.
- 3- ISSS enter notes in Sunapsis to indicate the student is a "potential dismissal."
- 4- ISSS reaches out to students to advise on their timeline to receive a final decision on their dismissal appeal (if they submit one) and to depart the United States. Appeal decisions must be finalized before the end of the two (2) week hold, before the dismissal is posted by the Registrar's office.
- 5- If at the end of the two (2) week period, the dismissal is rescinded, ISSS confirms with the Registrar's office that no dismissal is posted.
- 6- If at the end of the (2) week period, the dismissal will stand, ISSS confirms with the Registrar's office the dismissal is posted. ISSS emails the student the "termination warning" with the exact date the record will be terminated.

Expediting Dismissal Appeals:

Domestic students have a long period in which they can appeal a dismissal. International students have no more than two weeks from the date a dismissal notification is sent out. Students must consult with their academic advisor on their eligibility to appeal and to request to have the process expedited by the Dean. Usually appeals for international students are reviewed by the Dean within one or two days.

Determining the Termination Date:

Once the Registrar's office posts a dismissal, ISSS has up to 21 days to report it in SEVIS. Usually, students are terminated within 2 weeks.

Administrative Separation

PSE/IAP/MAP/ACDC students who fail to maintain minimum program requirements are administratively separated from the program. The administrative separation is similar to a dismissal. Their SEVIS record are terminated based on expulsion with remarks "academic dismissal."

The point person for administrative separations is Ken Janjigian.

The process for administrative separations is as follows:

1. Ken sends a list of administratively separated students.
2. ISSS confirms with Ken the list is final and the students were notified by the academic department (ISSS and students must be notified at the same time).

3. ISSS email students the “termination warning” with the exact date the record will be terminated. The termination warning can be sent only after confirmation the administrative separation letter was sent out to students. ISSS cannot be the first office to notify students.

Administratively separated students do not have the two (2) week hold period.

Once Ken notifies ISSS of final administrative separations, ISSS has up to 21 days to report it in SEVIS. Usually, students are terminated within 2 weeks.

Suspension

F-1 students who are not permitted on campus or are not permitted to attend classes due to suspension or interim suspension have their SEVIS record terminated based on suspension.

Suspensions can be effective immediately or at a future academic term. Students receive a suspension letter with the effective dates.

Students with suspension effective immediately must depart the United States as soon as they can, and their SEVIS record is terminated within 21 days of the decision effective date.

Students with suspension effective at the next academic term, and who are allowed to stay to finish the current semester, must depart the United States as soon as they finish their courses. Their SEVIS record is terminated within 21 days or less of the suspension effective date.

Students who are suspended at the end of spring with an effective date of fall are no longer entitled to summer vacation and must depart the United States as soon as they finish their courses in the spring. Unless they are enrolled in summer courses.

Most often ISSS is notified of suspensions through Alison Thomas, one of the Academic Integrity Code Administrators. The Registrar’s office point of contact for suspensions is Michael Hunnicutt.

Change of Status (COS)

F-1 students who change status to another immigration status must send proof of their new status to ISSS at issimmigration@american.edu

Students who changed status in the U.S. may submit a copy of their Approval Notice, Form I-797 Notice of Action as proof. Students who changed status by travel may submit a copy of their new visa, I-94 admission record or a copy of their entry stamp.

ISSS advises students to maintain their F-1 status until final approval of their new status.

COS Process for Current Students

1. Upon confirmation of the new immigration status, ISSS saves proof in Sunapsis.
2. ISSS terminates the F-1 status in SEVIS based on change of status approved with remarks "student changed status to"
3. ISSS ensures the termination in SEVIS is reflected in Sunapsis.
4. ISSS updates FPER (Foreign Person) in Colleague with the new immigration status by selecting the new "Visa Type." The Alien Status/Reg Nu must always show as "UNSP Unspecified." Click on "save all."
5. ISSS notifies the student by email the above action was taken.

COS Process for Students Who Graduated

Students who graduated and are still maintaining F-1 status, for example, students on post-completion OPT, have their SEVIS record terminated in SEVIS.

1. Upon confirmation of the new immigration status, ISSS saves proof in Sunapsis.
2. ISSS terminates the F-1 status in SEVIS based on change of status approved with remarks "student changed status to"
3. ISSS ensures the termination in SEVIS is reflected in Sunapsis.
4. ISSS notifies the student by email the above action was taken.

In this case, Colleague should not be updated.

COS Process for Students with a Terminated SEVIS Record

Sometimes, students who had their SEVIS terminated based on approved temporary leave or voluntary separation may come back to ISSS to request that their immigration status is updated within the university's system to reflect their change of status pending application.

For example, a student applies for temporary leave and has the SEVIS terminated based on authorized early withdrawal. Months later the student contacts ISSS saying applied for permanent residency, received the EAD, and plans not to enroll under the F-1 status next semester.

In this scenario, ISSS can update FPER (Foreign Person) in Colleague with "permanent resident change of status pending" in the "Visa Type" field. The Alien Status/Reg Nu must always show as "UNSP Unspecified." Click on "save all."

Otherwise Failing to Maintain Status

This termination reason is usually used for students that stop attending classes in programs where course attendance is a program requirement.

Scenarios:

1. ELTA and PSE students who stops attending classes and/or receives FX or ZX in any classes.
2. IAP, MAP, ACDC students who stops attending classes and/or receives FX or ZX in a required course or that places them below full-time enrollment.

Termination of F-2 Dependents

F-2 dependents are terminated for the following reasons: child over 21, death, divorce, other.

ISSS asks F-1 students to provide any updated information on their dependents in writing before F-2 records are terminated in SEVIS.

Terminations based on “other” are usually used in cases where dependents are no longer interested in entering the U.S. using an F-2 status or have departed the U.S. without any intention of returning using their F-2 status. Explanatory remarks are entered in SEVIS.

Administrative Separation for Failure to Enroll

Students who have not graduated and do not enroll by the last day to add and drop and who fail to request temporary leave, withdrawal, or voluntary separation, are administratively separated from AU.

ISSS terminates their SEVIS record based on failure to enroll. Sample case: 4518168

TRANSFER OUT

Students can request to have their active or terminated SEVIS record transferred out to another school in the United States.

Complex transfer out cases must be discussed and approved by the PDSO.

Immigration Eligibility for Active Transfer

ISSS practice is to assess students’ immigration eligibility to transfer in active status before the record is released. Transfers are processed after final grades are posted or confirmation of successful program completion.

Once ISSS is notified of potential dismissals or administrative separations, the practice is to wait for the final decision before ISSS can release the record.

Post-completion OPT – records are transferred in active status if the record has not been auto terminated by SEVIS.

Five (5) Month Rule

For active immigration transfers, the new academic program must start within five (5) months of:

1. the student's last day of classes or last day of attendance for current students.
2. the student's program completion date for graduating students.
3. the students' last day of work or end of authorization period for students on post-completion OPT or AT who are employed. For unemployed students, the five months start counting from their program completion date.

Transfer Period

Current students - transfers can be processed between semesters, after grades are posted and before the first day of classes. Mid semester transfers are not possible (with rare exceptions, after PDSO approval). Summer transfers can happen at any time.

Graduating students (students in their final academic term) - transfers can be processed after grades are posted and during the 60-day grace period (F-1) or 30-day grace period (J-1) after program completion.

OPT or AT students - for students on active Post-completion Optional Practical Training (OPT), active Post-completion Academic Training (AT), or active STEM OPT Extension, transfers can be processed at any time, including during the 60-day grace period after finishing OPT or the 30-day grace period after finishing AT. Students are required to stop employment at least a day before their selected transfer-out (SEVIS release) date. Their OPT or AT will automatically end in the immigration system on their transfer out (SEVIS release) date.

Transfers with Pending Termination

Students who have been scheduled for termination based on dismissal, administrative separation, or suspension cannot have their SEVIS released in "active" status. They can request to have their record released in "terminated" status any time before the initial termination date.

Once records have been terminated, students may request to have it transferred out at any time. Students must receive confirmation in writing from the new school that they will accept their terminated record. Students must attach this confirmation in the transfer out e-form.

Transfer Out Process

1. Students receive an admission letter from the new school.
2. Students contact the new school to collect the following required information:

- The new school's "transfer-in" form to be filled out by AU (if applicable). Not all schools make use of a "transfer-in" form. Additionally, some schools use electronic "transfer-in" forms. Electronic "transfer-in" forms should be emailed to issimmigration@american.edu.
 - The new school's "SEVIS school code" in which the immigration record can be transferred to.
 - If the new school has multiple campuses, the name of the campus in which the immigration record can be transferred out.
 - Students with a terminated record must receive confirmation in writing that the new school will accept their record.
3. Students decide on their transfer out (SEVIS release) date.
- They confirm with the new school if their desired transfer out (SEVIS release) date is acceptable for them. They ensure the new school has enough time to create their new I-20/DS-2019 prior to the start of the new academic program.
 - If they to travel abroad after transferring out, they must re-enter to the U.S. using their new school's I-20.
4. Student submits the transfer out request through [iEagle](#). Click on "Current Student" > "SEVIS Transfer-Out Request" and fill out the e-form.
5. ISSS reviews requests within 3-5 business days.
6. Transfers are processed after final grades are posted or there is confirmation of successful program completion (for transfers in active status).

Voluntary Separation or Graduation

Not graduating students: the transfer of their immigration status (SEVIS record) to the new school will not automatically end their academic status at AU.

They must inform their academic advisor of their decision to transfer out and to submit all required university forms to formally end their academic status at AU. Tuition and fee balances will continue to accrue unless they formally end their academic status.

Transfers must be scheduled before the voluntary separation is processed by the Registrar's office.

Graduating students: their degree will be posted by the Registrar's office after their degree clearance is finalized.

1 APPENDIX: HOW TO UPDATE THIS DOCUMENT

For 508 Compliance:

1. Use Calibri 12-point font
2. Text and Pictures are separated in tables
3. Use table of contents and update table when information has been updated in the document. Styles:
 - a. Heading 1
 - b. H2
 - c. H3a
 - d. Heading 4, 5, 6
4. DO NOT use a multiple “Enter” keystrokes or “Tab” for spacing between paragraphs. Apply 12 pts “**after**” under the spacing section of the Layout tab.
5. Use page and section breaks to move text to next page instead of “enter” or “tab”.
6. Pictures are formatted with the **Wrap Text** as “Top and Bottom” or “Tight”; positioning is set to center; and there is a .75 black border.